

Cortex XSIAM 3.5 Release Highlights



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Cortex XSIAM 3.5 Release Highlights

New Features Documentation - May 2026

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Source: Palo Alto Networks Cortex XSIAM 3.x Release Notes

Executive Summary

Cortex XSIAM 3.5 represents a significant milestone in autonomous security operations, introducing seven major features that transform how security teams detect, investigate, and respond to threats. This release emphasizes AI-driven automation, enhanced query capabilities, improved case management, and granular access controls.

Key Themes: - **Autonomous Operations:** Automated playbooks and AI-driven response capabilities - **Enhanced Analytics:** Advanced XQL functions and natural language visualizations - **Improved Workflows:** Streamlined case management and timeline views - **Stronger Governance:** Granular access controls and identity-based response

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1. Autonomous Playbooks

Overview

Autonomous Playbooks represent a groundbreaking approach to security automation, providing immediate, robust, and advanced security value from day one. This feature targets the investigation and response of Cortex Analytics alerts, replacing the legacy core Investigation and Response content pack with an enhanced, fully managed, next-generation experience.

Availability: Enabled by default for all new tenants created on or after May 31st, 2026. Existing tenants can request activation through Customer Support.

License: All licenses

The Challenge

Security teams face a frustrating paradox: the need to automate is urgent, but the journey to get there is slow, complex, and resource-intensive. Turning everyday security processes into reliable automation requires deep, constantly evolving security knowledge that most organizations struggle to develop and maintain.

Key Features

Immediate Value with Analyst-Level Quality

- Provides immediate, robust security value from day one
- Significantly reduces Mean Time to Respond (MTTR)
- Leverages Palo Alto Networks' deep security knowledge and research
- Zero customization required
- Comprehensive and accurate automation content
- Built-in guardrails: sensitive actions require analyst approval

Use-Case Specific Design

- **Atomic Playbooks:** Precisely tailored to resolve a single issue or specific group of similar issues

- Not monolithic or “reference” playbooks
- Thoroughly tested and qualified by PANW research team
- Delivers the highest standard of automated response available

Zero Customization Required

- Works out-of-the-box with no setup required
- No maintenance overhead
- Ready-to-run design
- Logic remains pristine and highly effective
- Always aligned with PANW latest updates

Full Ownership and System-Managed Updates

- PANW takes full ownership of expansion and maintenance
- Content updates seamlessly managed by the system
- All available playbooks automatically adopted when feature is enabled
- Associated automation rules automatically configured
- New playbooks automatically adopted and activated
- Updates to existing playbooks applied automatically
- No user dependency for updates

Streamlined Post-Run Visibility

- New workplan view filters out noise
- Linear process showing only executed key actions
- Clear, immediate picture of case status
- Focused reflection of actions taken
- No need to sift through complex backend steps

Focused User Experience

- Redesigned playbook interface
- Surfaces key information
- High-level visual structure

- Clear explainability of automation process
- Dedicated “Potential Response” section
- Highlights impactful commands and actions
- Flags actions requiring manual approval
- Shows assets excluded by exclusion policies

Business Impact

- **Immediate Protection:** Day-one security value without configuration
- **Reduced MTTR:** Automated investigation and response
- **Resource Optimization:** Eliminates playbook maintenance overhead
- **Expert Knowledge:** Leverages PANW elite security expertise
- **Consistent Updates:** Always current with latest threat intelligence
- **No Additional Cost:** Included without extra licensing fees

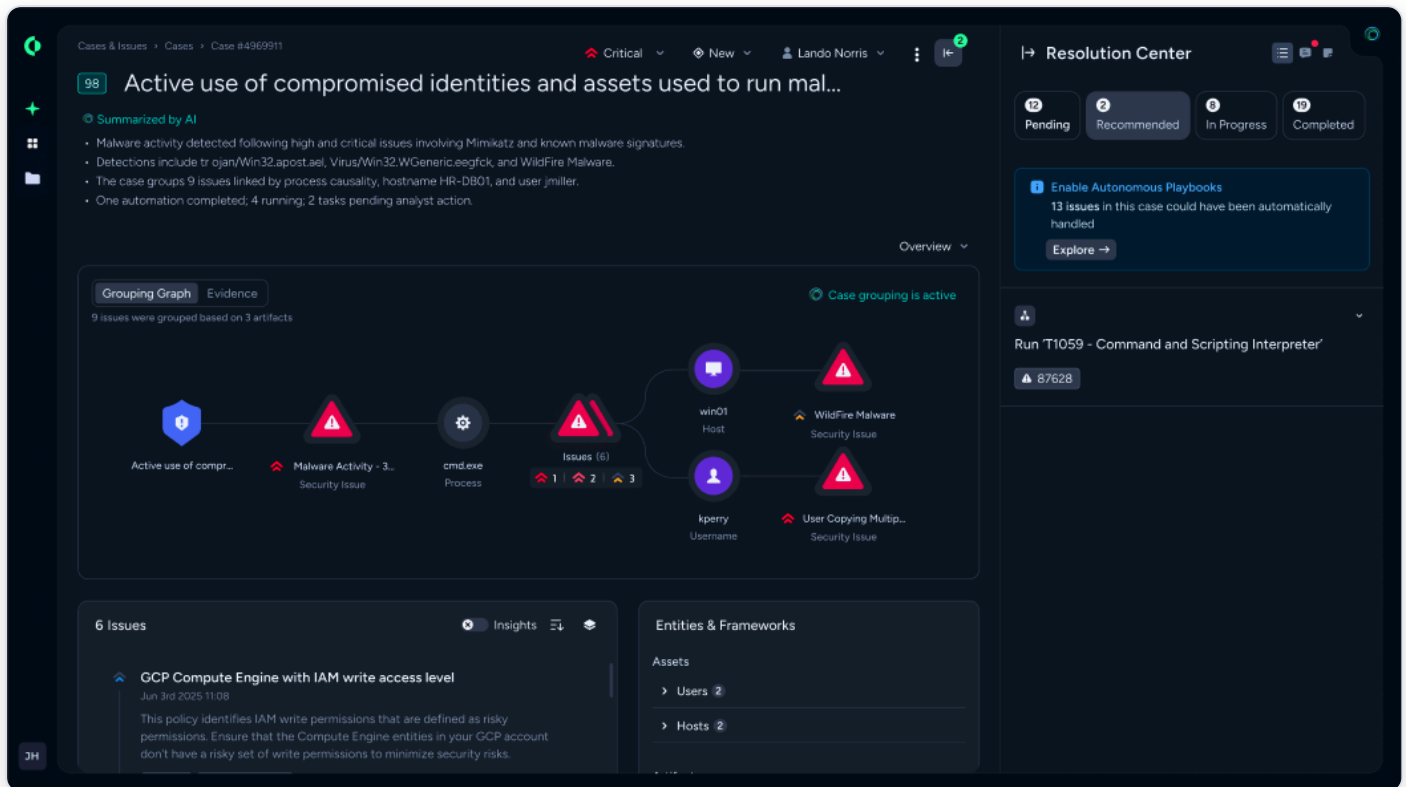
Use Cases

- Automated investigation of Cortex Analytics alerts
- Immediate threat response without manual intervention
- Consistent application of security best practices
- Rapid deployment of new detection capabilities
- Maintenance-free automation workflows

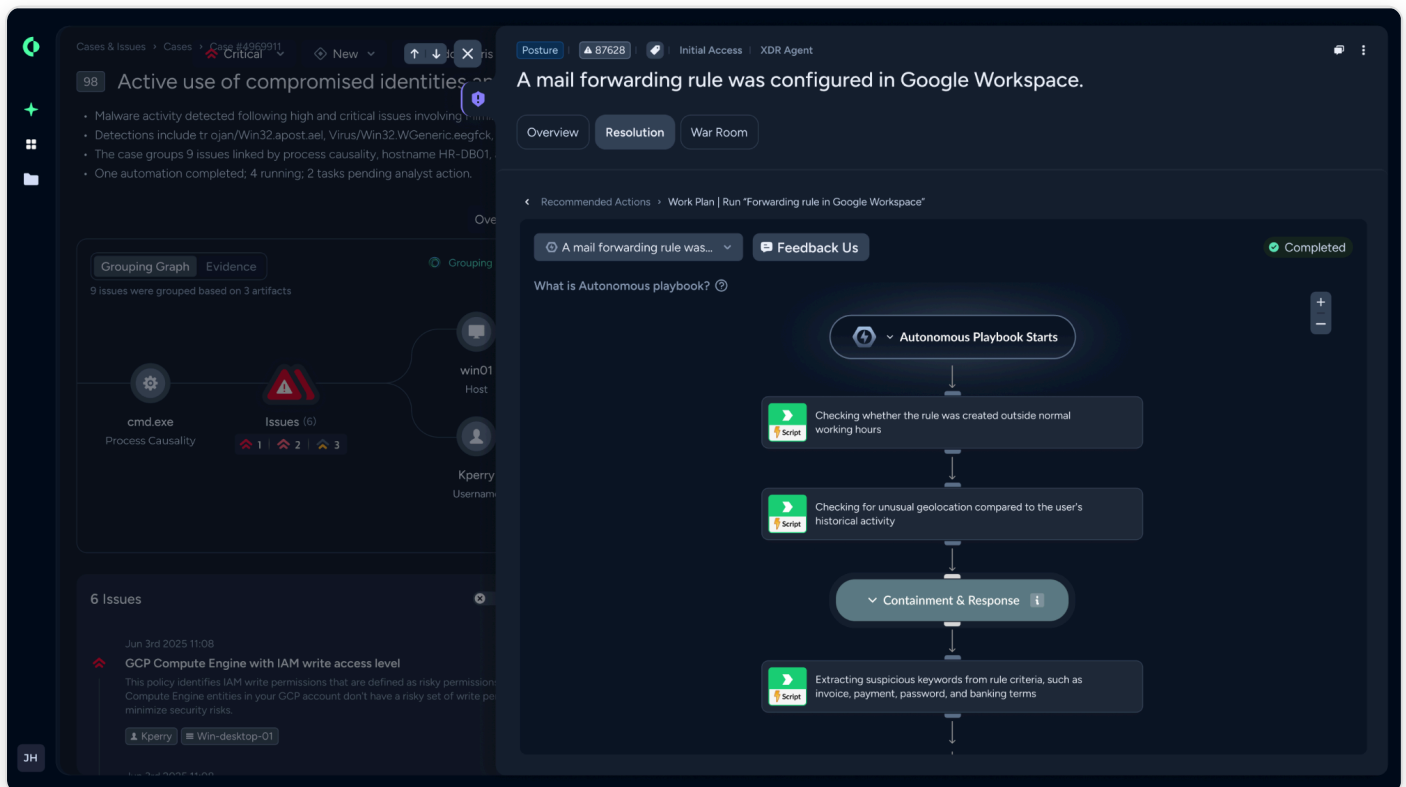
Technical Details

- Replaces legacy core Investigation and Response content pack
- Automatically enabled for new tenants (May 31, 2026+)
- Existing tenants: Contact support for activation
- Fully managed by Palo Alto Networks
- System-managed updates and expansions

Visual Overview



Deploy instant-on expert automation without custom engineering with the new Autonomous Playbooks capability



New workplan view, providing focused reflection of executed actions

Documentation References

- [Unveiling Autonomous Playbooks Blog Post](#)
 - [XSIAM Alert Handling Playbooks](#)
 - [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#)
 - [Cortex XSIAM Product Page](#)
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2. Agentic Response

Overview

Agentic Response enables security teams to configure AI agents that automatically investigate and resolve threats in real time, delivering autonomous, end-to-end analysis and remediation. This feature moves beyond rigid playbooks to provide dynamic, intelligent threat response.

Availability: Private Preview (contact Cortex Product Management to participate)

License: All licenses

Key Features

Automatic Threat Investigation

- AI agents automatically triggered via automation rules
- Build multi-step investigation plans dynamically
- Analyze novel threats in real time
- Take response actions autonomously
- Adapt to unique threat scenarios

Intelligent Planning and Reasoning

- Multi-step investigation plan generation
- Context-aware decision making
- Novel threat analysis capabilities
- Real-time threat assessment

- Dynamic response strategy development

Human-in-the-Loop Controls

- Built-in approval workflows for sensitive actions
- Team maintains control over critical operations
- Configurable approval requirements
- Audit trail of all AI agent actions
- Balance between automation and oversight

Real-Time Response

- Immediate threat analysis
- Automated remediation actions
- Continuous threat monitoring
- Adaptive response strategies
- End-to-end autonomous operations

Business Impact

- **Faster Response:** Real-time threat investigation and remediation
- **Scalable Operations:** AI agents handle multiple threats simultaneously
- **Consistent Quality:** Standardized investigation and response processes
- **Reduced Workload:** Analysts focus on strategic tasks
- **24/7 Coverage:** Continuous autonomous threat response

Use Cases

- Automated incident investigation
- Real-time threat remediation
- Novel threat analysis
- Multi-stage attack response
- Continuous threat hunting

Integration

- Triggered via automation rules
- Integrates with existing XSIAM workflows
- Compatible with Cortex Analytics alerts
- Works alongside Autonomous Playbooks
- Supports custom response actions

Technical Details

- Currently in Private Preview
- Contact Cortex Product Management for access
- Requires automation rule configuration
- Supports sensitive action approvals
- Full audit logging

Documentation References

- [Cortex Agentic Assistant](#)
- [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#)
- [Cortex XSIAM Product Page](#)

Note: Agentic Response is currently in Private Preview. Contact Cortex Product Management for access to configuration guides and implementation documentation.

3. Enhanced XQL

Overview

Enhanced XQL (Cortex Query Language) introduces powerful new capabilities that turn queries into real-time analysis tools. With over 30 new mathematical functions, autosave functionality, and personalized views, analysts can uncover anomalies, refine results, and answer complex questions more efficiently than ever before.

License: All licenses

Key Features

30+ New Mathematical Functions

- Advanced statistical analysis
- Anomaly detection capabilities
- Behavioral baselining
- Outlier identification
- Real-time pattern analysis
- Complex calculations
- Data transformation functions

Autosave Functionality

- Automatic query preservation
- Never lose work in progress
- Seamless session recovery
- Continuous progress saving
- Protection against data loss

Personalized Views

- Save custom query configurations
- Preserve analyst workflows
- Store preferred settings
- Quick access to common queries
- Team collaboration support

Enhanced Analysis Capabilities

- Deeper real-time analysis
- Baseline behavior establishment
- Identify statistical outliers
- Uncover hidden patterns
- Reduce repetitive work

- Accelerate investigations

Business Impact

- **Faster Investigations:** Advanced functions speed up analysis
- **Improved Accuracy:** Mathematical precision in threat detection
- **Reduced Rework:** Autosave prevents lost progress
- **Better Collaboration:** Shared personalized views
- **Enhanced Productivity:** Less time on repetitive queries

Use Cases

- Behavioral anomaly detection
- Statistical threat analysis
- Trend identification
- Performance baselining
- Complex data correlations
- Historical pattern analysis

Technical Capabilities

- Real-time mathematical operations
- Statistical analysis functions
- Data aggregation and transformation
- Time-series analysis
- Percentile calculations
- Standard deviation analysis
- Moving averages
- Correlation functions

Workflow Improvements

- Pick up exactly where you left off
- No need to rebuild queries

- Preserve investigation context
- Share analysis templates
- Standardize query approaches

Documentation References

- [XQL Query Engine Integration](#) - XQL query execution guide
 - [XQL Helper Scripts](#) - XQL visualization and analysis
 - [Cortex XQL Queries GitHub Repository](#) - Community XQL query examples
 - [XQL Query Language Overview](#) - High-level XQL introduction
 - [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#) - Feature announcement
 - [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#)
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4. Case Timeline View

Overview

The Case Timeline View provides a streamlined, automatically generated workspace that captures the entire investigation lifecycle. This feature automatically documents attack activity, analyst actions, evidence, attachments, and XQL results in a centralized, chronological view.

License: All licenses

Key Features

Automated Documentation

- Automatically captures all case activity
- Chronological event tracking
- Complete investigation history
- No manual documentation required
- Real-time updates

Comprehensive Activity Capture

- Attack activity timeline
- Analyst actions and decisions
- Evidence collection
- File attachments
- XQL query results
- System events
- Response actions
- Communication logs

Centralized Workspace

- Single view for entire investigation
- End-to-end case visibility
- Unified evidence repository
- Integrated analysis tools
- Collaborative workspace

Context Preservation

- Maintains investigation context
- Shows relationship between events
- Tracks decision rationale
- Documents response actions
- Preserves analyst insights

Simplified Collaboration

- Team members see complete picture
- Easy handoff between shifts
- Clear audit trail
- Shared understanding of case status
- Reduced communication overhead

Business Impact

- **Time Savings:** Eliminates manual documentation
- **Better Context:** Complete investigation visibility
- **Improved Collaboration:** Shared workspace for teams
- **Faster Handoffs:** Clear case status for shift changes
- **Audit Readiness:** Automatic compliance documentation

Use Cases

- Complex incident investigations
- Multi-analyst case collaboration
- Shift handoffs
- Management reporting
- Compliance documentation
- Post-incident reviews
- Training and knowledge transfer

Workflow Benefits

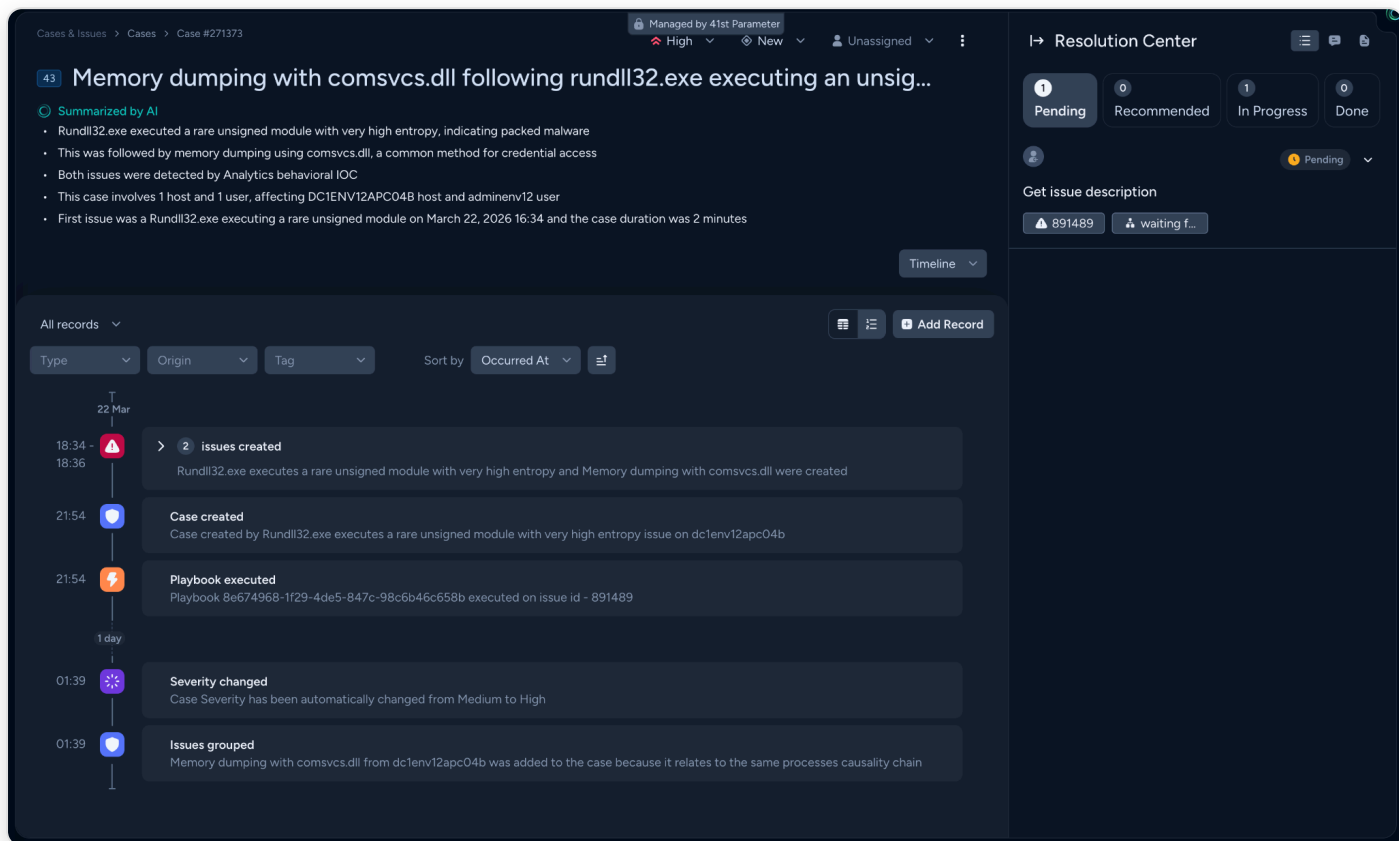
- Automatic timeline generation
- No manual note-taking required
- Visual representation of investigation flow
- Easy identification of key events
- Quick access to all evidence
- Simplified case reviews

Technical Features

- Real-time timeline updates
- Automatic event correlation
- Evidence attachment support
- XQL result integration
- Customizable views

- Export capabilities

Visual Overview



New Case Timeline View provides a high-velocity, automated workspace

Documentation References

- [Cortex Incident and Case Management](#)
- [Case Management - Generic v2 Playbook](#)
- [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#)
- [Cortex XSIAM Product Page](#)

5. Natural Language Visualizations

Overview

Natural Language Visualizations enable analysts to turn simple questions into charts and build custom widgets in seconds using the Cortex Agentic Assistant. This feature eliminates the need

for manual queries and coding, allowing security teams to quickly make sense of massive data volumes.

License: All licenses

Key Features

Question-to-Chart Conversion

- Turn natural language questions into visualizations
- Instant chart generation
- No coding required
- Multiple visualization types
- Interactive dashboards

Cortex Agentic Assistant Integration

- AI-powered visualization creation
- Intelligent chart type selection
- Automatic data formatting
- Context-aware recommendations
- Natural language processing

Custom Widget Creation

- Build widgets without coding
- Drag-and-drop simplicity
- Customizable layouts
- Reusable templates
- Team sharing capabilities

Rapid Insights

- Identify security trends instantly
- Spot patterns faster
- Accelerate decision making

- Visual data exploration
- Real-time analysis

Simplified Data Analysis

- No query language expertise needed
- Intuitive interface
- Automatic data aggregation
- Smart visualization suggestions
- Interactive exploration

Business Impact

- **Democratized Analytics:** Non-technical users can create visualizations
- **Faster Insights:** Seconds instead of minutes or hours
- **Improved Communication:** Visual representation of threats
- **Better Decisions:** Quick pattern identification
- **Reduced Training:** Minimal learning curve

Use Cases

- Threat trend analysis
- Security metrics dashboards
- Executive reporting
- Incident pattern identification
- Performance monitoring
- Compliance reporting
- Team collaboration

Capabilities

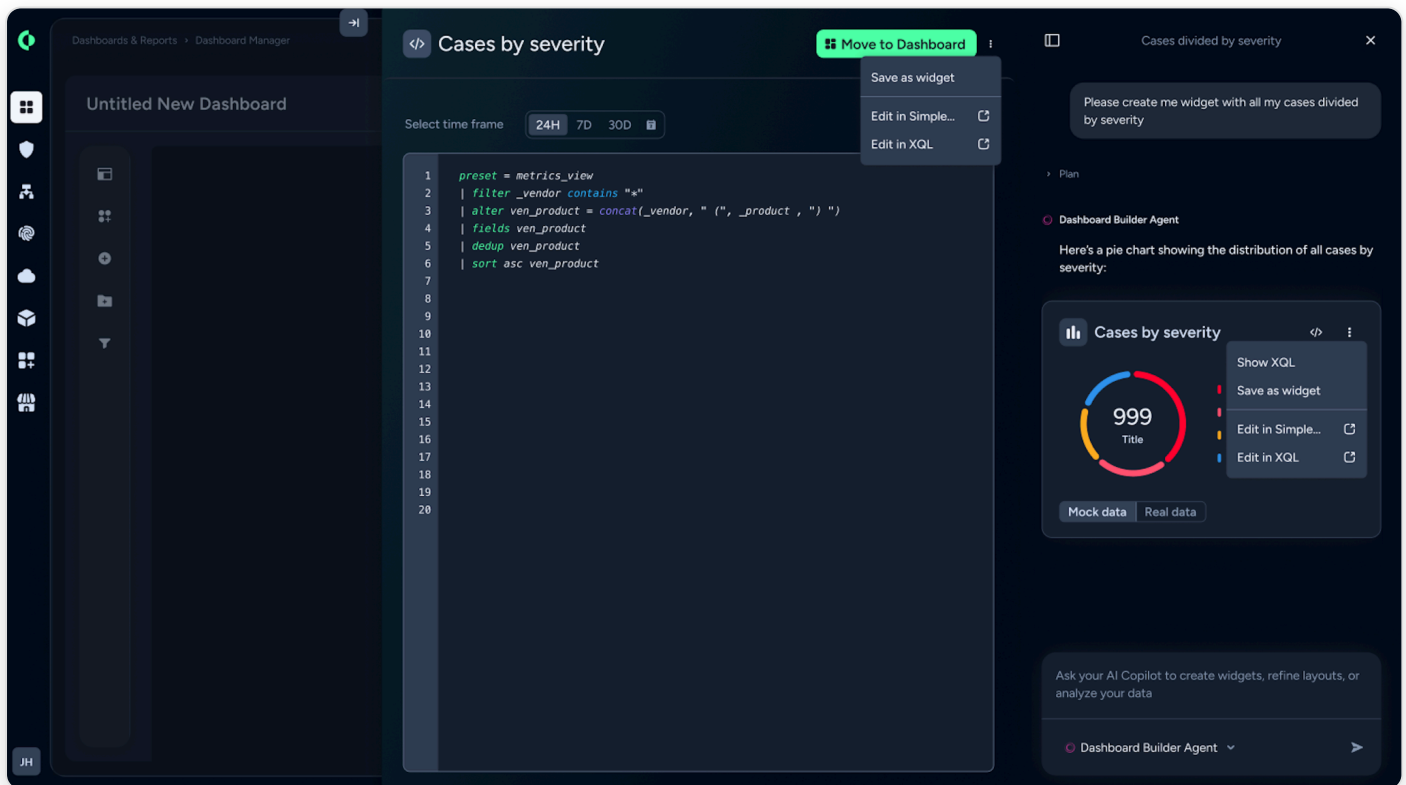
- Multiple chart types (bar, line, pie, scatter, etc.)
- Time-series visualizations
- Comparative analysis

- Trend identification
- Anomaly highlighting
- Custom color schemes
- Interactive filtering

Workflow Integration

- Works with existing XSIAM data
- Integrates with XQL queries
- Compatible with dashboards
- Supports report generation
- Enables ad-hoc analysis

Visual Overview



New Natural Language Visualization reveals trends and insights instantly

Documentation References

- [Cortex Agentic Assistant](#)
- [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#)

- [Cortex XSIAM Product Page](#)
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6. Granular Per-Object Access

Overview

Granular Per-Object Access strengthens least-privilege access controls by allowing administrators to define specific permissions for user groups across critical security assets including report templates, playbooks, scripts, and saved queries.

License: All licenses

Key Features

Fine-Grained Permissions

- User group-level access control
- Object-specific permissions
- Role-based access management
- Customizable permission sets
- Inheritance support

Supported Objects

- **Report Templates:** Control who can view, edit, or execute reports
- **Playbooks:** Manage playbook access and modification rights
- **Scripts:** Restrict script execution and editing
- **Saved Queries:** Control query access and sharing

Least-Privilege Enforcement

- Minimum necessary access
- Reduced attack surface
- Compliance alignment
- Audit trail support

- Risk mitigation

Improved Governance

- Clear permission structure
- Centralized access management
- Policy enforcement
- Compliance support
- Audit readiness

Reduced Exposure

- Limit access to sensitive workflows
- Protect critical automation
- Prevent unauthorized changes
- Secure proprietary queries
- Control data access

Business Impact

- **Enhanced Security:** Reduced risk of unauthorized access
- **Compliance:** Meet regulatory requirements
- **Operational Safety:** Prevent accidental changes
- **Clear Accountability:** Track who has access to what
- **Simplified Management:** Centralized permission control

Use Cases

- Multi-tenant environments
- MSSP operations
- Compliance requirements (SOC 2, ISO 27001)
- Separation of duties
- Contractor access management
- Training environments
- Development vs. production separation

Permission Types

- **View:** Read-only access
- **Edit:** Modification rights
- **Execute:** Run playbooks/scripts
- **Delete:** Removal permissions
- **Share:** Distribution rights
- **Admin:** Full control

Implementation

- Define user groups
- Assign permissions per object
- Set inheritance rules
- Configure approval workflows
- Monitor access patterns

Compliance Benefits

- Supports SOC 2 requirements
- Enables ISO 27001 compliance
- Facilitates GDPR adherence
- Meets HIPAA standards
- Supports PCI-DSS controls

Documentation References

- [Role-based Permission Levels](#) - Permission configuration guide
 - [Integration Permissions](#) - Integration-level permissions
 - [Transforming SecOps Using XSIAM Design Guide](#) - XSIAM design and access control guidance
 - [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#)
 - [Cortex XSIAM Product Page](#)
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7. Identity and Privilege-Based SOC Response

Overview

This feature enables security teams to instantly disrupt the kill chain with minimal user impact by validating identity and dynamically limiting privileges via CyberArk Endpoint Privilege Manager integration. Available through the Cortex Marketplace, this capability provides identity-aware, privilege-based response actions.

Availability: Cortex Marketplace

Requirements: CyberArk EPM license

License: All licenses

Key Features

Identity Validation

- Real-time identity verification
- User context awareness
- Authentication status checking
- Privilege level assessment
- Risk-based validation

Dynamic Privilege Restriction

- Real-time privilege limitation
- Temporary access reduction
- Automated privilege revocation
- Granular control
- Minimal user disruption

CyberArk EPM Integration

- Native integration with CyberArk Endpoint Privilege Manager
- Seamless privilege management
- Automated policy enforcement

- Real-time privilege adjustment
- Comprehensive audit logging

Kill Chain Disruption

- Early attack interruption
- Prevent lateral movement
- Block privilege escalation
- Contain compromised accounts
- Minimize blast radius

Minimal Operational Impact

- Surgical response actions
- Targeted privilege restrictions
- User productivity maintained
- Business continuity preserved
- Reversible actions

Business Impact

- **Faster Containment:** Immediate threat isolation
- **Reduced Impact:** Minimal disruption to legitimate users
- **Better Protection:** Identity-aware response
- **Compliance:** Privilege management audit trails
- **Cost Efficiency:** Prevent widespread damage

Use Cases

- Compromised account response
- Insider threat mitigation
- Privilege escalation prevention
- Lateral movement blocking
- Zero-trust enforcement
- Incident containment

- Automated threat response

Integration Architecture

- **Cortex XSIAM:** Threat detection and orchestration
- **CyberArk EPM:** Privilege management and enforcement
- **Cortex Marketplace:** Integration deployment
- **Automation Rules:** Trigger privilege actions
- **Playbooks:** Orchestrate response workflows

Response Actions

- Reduce user privileges temporarily
- Revoke specific permissions
- Require re-authentication
- Block application execution
- Limit network access
- Enforce MFA
- Quarantine endpoints

Technical Requirements

- CyberArk EPM license
- Cortex XSIAM deployment
- Marketplace integration installation
- Network connectivity between systems
- Proper API permissions

Workflow Example

1. **Detection:** Cortex Analytics identifies suspicious activity
2. **Validation:** Identity and privilege context assessed
3. **Decision:** Automated or analyst-approved response
4. **Action:** CyberArk EPM restricts privileges

5. **Monitoring:** Continuous assessment of threat status
6. **Restoration:** Privileges restored when safe

Security Benefits

- **Early Disruption:** Stop attacks before damage occurs
- **Precision Response:** Target specific threats without broad impact
- **Identity Context:** Understand who is affected
- **Privilege Awareness:** Know what access is at risk
- **Automated Protection:** Respond faster than manual processes

Documentation References

- [Cortex Marketplace](#)
- [Idira Endpoint Privilege Manager](#)
- [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#)
- [Cortex XSIAM Product Page](#)

Note: For CyberArk EPM integration setup and configuration, refer to the integration documentation available in the Cortex Marketplace or contact your CyberArk and Palo Alto Networks representatives.

Additional Enhancements

General Enhancements

Administrator Control for Saved Views and Filters

- Remove unused or outdated saved views
- Delete filters created by other users
- Keep workspace clean and relevant
- Improve system performance
- Reduce clutter

Documentation References: - [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#) - [Cortex XSIAM Product Page](#)

Enhanced Notification Forwarding

- Additional asset information in notifications
- Remediation details included
- Expanded notification fields:
 - Asset name
 - Cloud resource name
 - Asset tags
 - Account name
 - Region
 - Evidence
- Supported destinations:
 - Amazon S3
 - Amazon SQS
 - Webhook
 - Splunk
 - Email

Documentation References: - [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#) - [Cortex XSIAM Product Page](#)

Import Method Selection for BYOK

- Select encryption key import method
- Greater data sovereignty
- Enhanced control over encryption
- Simplified key management
- Compliance support

Documentation References: - [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#) - [Cortex XSIAM Product Page](#)

Access Management

Expanding SBAC with Account Name

- Scope-Based Access Control enhancements
- Define Asset Groups with Account Name attribute
- More granular access policies
- Use existing Realm attribute for Account ID scoping
- Improved multi-account management

Documentation References: - [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#) - [Cortex XSIAM Product Page](#)

Summary

Cortex XSIAM 3.5 delivers transformative capabilities across seven major feature areas:

1. **Autonomous Playbooks** - Zero-touch automation with expert-level quality
2. **Agentic Response** - AI-driven investigation and remediation
3. **Enhanced XQL** - Advanced analytics with 30+ math functions
4. **Case Timeline View** - Automated investigation documentation
5. **Natural Language Visualizations** - Instant insights without coding
6. **Granular Per-Object Access** - Strengthened least-privilege controls
7. **Identity and Privilege-Based Response** - Surgical threat containment

These features collectively advance the vision of autonomous security operations, enabling security teams to detect, investigate, and respond to threats faster and more effectively than ever before.

Resources and Documentation

Official Documentation

- [What's New in Cortex \(May '26\)](#)
- [Unveiling Autonomous Playbooks](#)

Technical Documentation

- [XSIAM Alert Handling Playbooks](#) - Alert handling and playbook design
- [XQL Query Engine Integration](#) - XQL query execution guide
- [XQL Helper Scripts](#) - XQL visualization and analysis
- [Role-based Permission Levels](#) - RBAC configuration
- [Integration Permissions](#) - Permission management
- [Case Management Playbook](#) - Case management workflows

Product Pages

- [Cortex XSIAM](#)
- [Cortex Agentic Assistant](#)
- [Cortex Marketplace](#)
- [Cortex Incident and Case Management](#)
- [Idira Endpoint Privilege Manager](#)

Design Guides and Resources

- [Transforming SecOps Using XSIAM Design Guide](#)
- [Cortex XSIAM eBook](#)

Developer Resources

- [Cortex XQL Queries GitHub Repository](#)
- [XQL Query Language Overview](#)

Contact

- **Private Preview Access:** Contact Cortex Product Management
- **Feature Activation:** Contact Customer Support
- **Technical Support:** [Palo Alto Networks Support](#)

Note: For detailed technical documentation, configuration guides, and API references, please access the documentation portal through your Cortex XSIAM tenant or contact Palo Alto Networks Support for assistance.

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